



CorelDRAW Graphics Suite X3

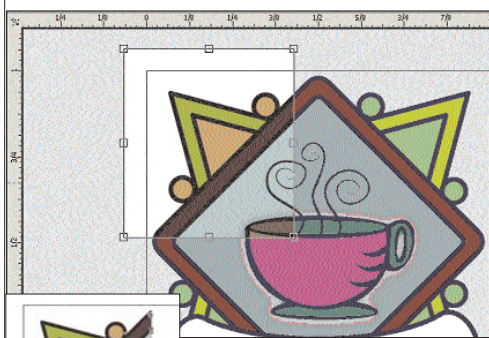
A Formidable Design Tool

Seventeen years after the first one, Corel breaks away from its earlier naming convention (version 13 unlucky, perhaps?) to release the CorelDRAW Graphics Suite X3. The box pack contains four CDs—one containing the program files for CorelDRAW, Corel Photo-Paint and Corel Capture, and the remaining three full to the brim with clipart and fonts.

Time and again, CorelDRAW has wowed us with its vast array of abilities and all within a small memory footprint—both DRAW and Photo-Paint are beautifully stable and light on resources.

Among the best new additions to CorelDRAW X3 is the Crop tool, which lets you crop vector graphics the same way you would raster—just select the area you want to keep, and double-click! No more hunting and deleting specific points on the curves. Another nifty tool is the Smart

Fill, which automatically estimates boundaries and only fills the space inside. We tried this by drawing a bunch of squares to create a haphazard boundary, and the Smart Fill filled the enclosed area precisely. Text and paragraph formatting is a breeze thanks to new DTP features, bringing CorelDRAW another step closer to becoming an excellent page layout program. In fact, the supplied font and clipart catalogue was laid out in CorelDRAW itself!



Now crop vector graphics just like bitmaps

Corel Trace, the tool for converting raster graphics to vector in CorelDRAW, is now Corel PowerTrace, and gives much better results when tracing bitmaps.

Both CorelDRAW and Corel

Photo-Paint are now much easier to learn thanks to the addition of a Hints pane on the right of the window, which tells you what to

do with the tool you've currently got selected—a boon for new users.

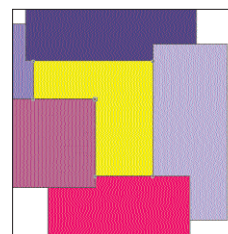
Photo-Paint has improved on performance, and we found it capable of handling complex files without any stability issues. When we decided to verify the claims that Photo-Paint is actually faster than

Adobe Photoshop in some respects, we were quite amazed—applying a Radial Blur (Amount: 10) to a 66 MB, 300 dpi TIFF file took Photoshop CS2 4 minutes and 17 seconds, and Photo-Paint a jaw-dropping 1 minute and 45 seconds! Its memory footprint is also much smaller with the image loaded: 104 MB to Photoshop's 167. Factor in the fact that the price of the entire suite is about two-thirds that of Photoshop, you have a product that inches ever so close to the Master itself.

The third application—Corel Capture—seems like a gratuitous addition. It's utterly pointless, especially when you consider other screen capture tools such as Snagit and HyperSnap. Ditto Font Navigator, which still seems to be stuck in the stone age of font managers.

Overall, CorelDRAW Graphics Suite X3 is an undoubted must for old and new users alike. It's lightweight and yet delivers features that will give your graphics a slick, professional look.

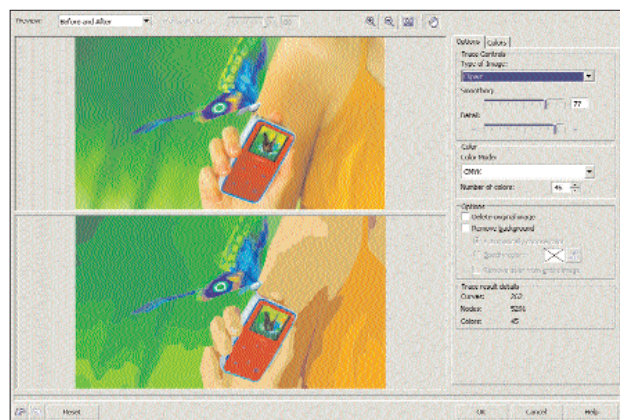
Try out CorelDRAW Graphics Suite X3 from this month's DVD.



The Smart Fill tool easily fills up enclosed areas. Here, we just made a rough boundary with squares and used the Smart Fill for the middle.



The Hints pane makes the new X3 Suite much easier to learn



Now trace bitmaps better with PowerTrace

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Rating

